



SHELLS FOUND IN LARGE NUMBERS; (LEFT) WORK IN PROGRESS AT THE KHIRSARA SITE

A PIECE OF A PERFORATED JAR FOUND AT THE SITE



HUNDREDS OF STEATITE BEADS UNCOVERED

A PIECE OF THE TERRACOTTA DISH-ON-STAND



ATION

that this coupled with the location of the site indicates that it could have been a crucial centre for cattle trading as well as the trade of bones and flesh of wild animals during the Harappan period. What supports the analysis of archaeologists is the fact that the site is landlocked amid hills and there is some amount of greenery there, while the rest of Kutch is largely arid. The recovery of the bones is also supportive of the impression that the Harappan people were hunters and traders of wild animals. The excavations at Dholavira in the 1990s, the largest Indus Valley civilisation site after Mohenjodaro and Harappa, too had yielded a large quantity of bones

of wild animals. Director of the Gujarat Archaeology Department Y.S. Rawat says, "So far, it was believed that the Harappan sites in north Gujarat were bigger suppliers of articles related to wild animals during the period. But now, after Dholavira and Khirsara, it can be said that Kutch was not so far behind." Rawat had assisted noted archaeologist R.S. Bisht in the excavation of Dholavira.

Significantly, the area has always been rich in minerals and semi-precious stones such as chert and chalcedony, and that imprint is obvious in the recovery of materials from the site during excavations. The

recovered beads in various shapes and sizes such as tubular and micro are made of semi-precious stones like agate, carnelian and jasper. Steatite beads, which are made by solidifying a certain paste by heating it at a certain temperature, have also been found

along with terracotta beads and figurines. The variety of pottery found is typically Harappan in style: pieces of perforated jars, dishes-on-stands, storage jars, large and small vessels, reserve slip pottery and painted pottery with floral and geometrical patterns. Reserve slip pottery is one of the common forms of Harappan pottery wherein the potter used his fingers to create reverse lines on a terracotta vessel. Before the experts began excavations, the villagers had also found two seals of terracotta from the site imprinted with typical characters of the Harappan language which remains undeciphered so far despite many claims. The fort wall, most visible on the north-eastern corner of the site, is made of dressed stones, which have also been used in the construction of the residential quarters.

The Khirsara story is similar to Dholavira's. It was identified by the Gujarat State Archaeology Department in 1970s, after which reputed scholars visited the site from time to time to explore it further. But the actual excavations at Khirsara only began this year. Dholavira, too, was explored in 1965 but the excavations at the site began in the 1990s. It indicates the low priority that successive governments have given to research of ancient Indian antiquity, since nearly 550 of the total 1,000 Harappan sites located in India are in Gujarat. The Khirsara excavations once again underscore that Gujarat remains a main focus in unraveling the mystery surrounding the Harappan civilisation. ■